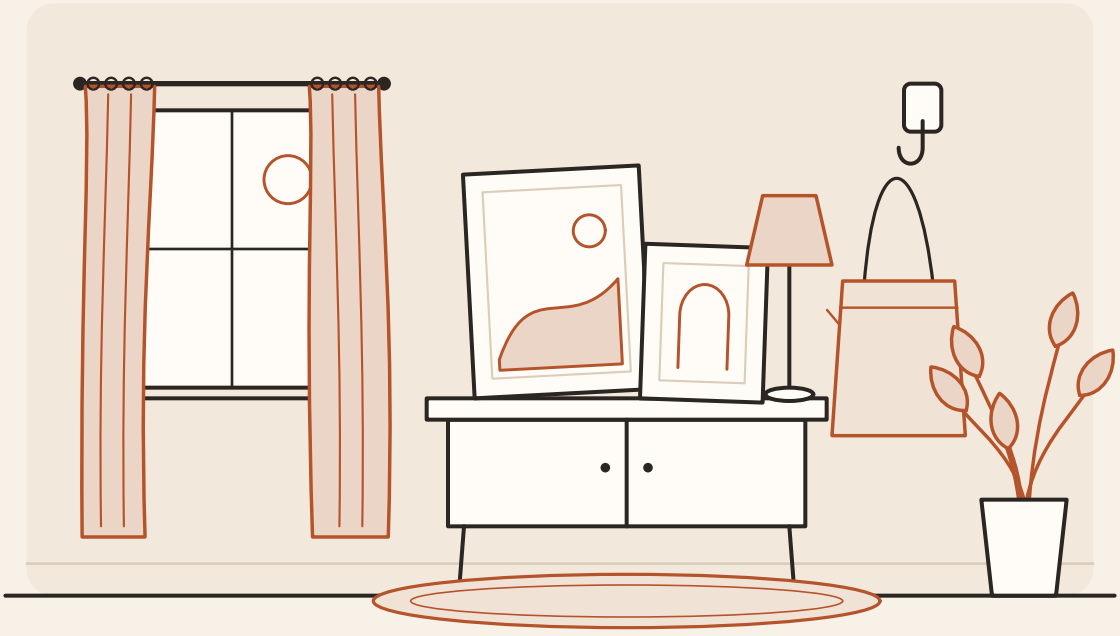
No Holes Needed

A FREE FIELD GUIDE FOR RENTERS & SMALL SPACES

The Renter's *Survival* Guide

Protect your deposit, hang things without a single hole, and make a small rented place actually work.



Move-in & move-out checklists • **No-drill hanging cheat sheet** • **Printable worksheets**

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START HERE

Rent it, love it, *leave it clean.*

Renting comes with a quiet rule: whatever you change, you have to un-change. This guide is the short version of what we cover on No Holes Needed, built around that rule. Every fix here is meant to come down clean, and every checklist leaves a paper trail that protects you.

How to use it. Print the worksheets, or fill them in on screen: the boxes and lines are clickable in most PDF readers. Do the move-in pages the day you get the keys, before a single box comes through the door. Keep the condition log and contact log in one folder with your lease. Then dip into the room fixes whenever something in the apartment is bugging you.

BRING TO MOVE-IN DAY

- [ ] Phone, fully charged, with room for a few hundred photos
- [ ] A coin or small tape measure for scale in close-ups
- [ ] A phone charger or night-light to test outlets
- [ ] A printed copy of the condition log (page 05)
- [ ] Painter's tape and sticky notes to flag spots

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A quick, honest note

This guide is general, practical information, not legal advice. Leases, deposit rules and repair rights differ by state, city and building. Before you rely on anything here, check your lease and your local landlord-tenant rules, and when in doubt, ask your landlord or property manager in writing. Product ratings change too: **always check the package rating** before you hang or install anything.

SECTION 01
THE FIRST 48 HOURS

Move-in checklist

A clear starting record makes later disagreements easier to resolve. Work through this before you unpack, with the place empty and the lights on.

Paperwork & basics

- [ ] Get a full copy of the signed lease, including any addenda and house rules
- [ ] Ask for the building's move-in condition form, and note the deadline to return it
- [ ] Write down how repair requests should be made (portal, email, phone) and who to contact after hours
- [ ] Photograph the meters (electric, gas, water) with readings visible
- [ ] Find the water shut-off, the breaker panel and the fire extinguisher
- [ ] Ask whether the locks were changed or rekeyed since the last tenant
- [ ] Set up utilities and internet in your name; note each start date
- [ ] Look into renters insurance before your first night

Safety

- [ ] Press the test button on every smoke and carbon-monoxide alarm
- [ ] Check that windows lock, and that bedroom windows open as an exit
- [ ] Note loose railings, steps or wobbly fixtures and report them in writing

Walk-through, room by room

- [ ] Flip every light switch; test every outlet with a charger or night-light
- [ ] Run each faucet hot and cold; look under sinks for drips, stains or soft spots
- [ ] Flush each toilet and listen for it running afterward
- [ ] Run the shower and check how fast the tub or shower drains
- [ ] Open, close and lock every door, window and closet; check screens and blinds
- [ ] Turn on the oven, each burner, the range hood and the dishwasher
- [ ] Check the fridge and freezer get cold, and the door seals are intact
- [ ] Look for signs of pests under sinks, behind appliances and in cabinets
- [ ] Note every existing nail hole, scuff, stain, chip, crack and scratch
- [ ] Check ceilings and window corners for water stains or mold spots

Put it in writing

Found problems? Email them the same week, with photos attached, and keep the reply. A dated email is far easier to point to later than a hallway conversation.

Keys & codes you were given

You'll need to return every one of these at move-out.

DOOR KEYS _____ MAILBOX _____ FOBS / CARDS _____ GARAGE / OTHER _____

CODES (GATE, LOCKBOX, WI-FI) _____ RECEIVED ON _____

SECTION 02
YOUR DEPOSIT'S BEST EVIDENCE

Photos that protect you

Shoot clearly, keep the originals and send your findings in writing. Allow extra time for every defect you find; a careful record beats a hurried camera roll.

1. **Shoot it empty.** Take photos before any furniture or boxes come in. An empty room shows the floors, walls and corners that furniture would hide for the next year.
2. **Same order, every room.** Start at the doorway with a wide shot, then stand in each corner. Then each wall, the floor and the ceiling. A fixed routine means you won't skip the hallway closet.
3. **Close-up, then context.** For every flaw, take a close-up with a coin or tape measure for scale, then a wider shot that shows where it is in the room.
4. **Open everything.** Inside cabinets and drawers, the oven, fridge and freezer, under sinks, closets, the tub, tile grout and window tracks.
5. **Add a slow video.** Walk through each room with the lights on and narrate what you see: "bedroom, scratch on the closet door, carpet stain by the window."
6. **Don't edit, do back up.** Keep the original files so the date and time stay attached. Copy the set to cloud storage, then email the landlord a link or a selection, so there's a dated record they received it.
7. **Name it so you can find it.** One folder: *Move-in – [address] – [date]*. You will be looking for it in a year, probably in a hurry.

Shot list for every room

- ☐ Wide shot from the doorway
- ☐ Each corner, looking in
- ☐ Each wall, straight on
- ☐ Floor, including edges and corners
- ☐ Ceiling, lights and fans
- ☐ Windows, blinds, screens, sills
- ☐ Outlets and switch plates
- ☐ Doors, hinges, handles, locks
- ☐ Inside closets and cabinets
- ☐ Close-ups of every flaw, with scale
- ☐ Appliances, inside and out
- ☐ A short narrated video

Repeat it at move-out

Stand in the same spots when you leave. Matching before-and-after photos are the easiest proof to compare.

Photo index

Jot down the photos that show each flaw, so you can find them in seconds later.

PHOTO #	ROOM	WHAT IT SHOWS	SENT
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

WORKSHEET FILL IN ON MOVE-IN DAY, KEEP WITH YOUR LEASE

Room-by-room condition log

ADDRESS _____ MOVE-IN DATE _____

SENT TO LANDLORD ON _____ HOW (EMAIL / PORTAL) _____

ROOM / AREA	CONDITION NOTES: EXISTING DAMAGE, WEAR, ANYTHING NOT WORKING	PHOTO TAKEN	REPORTED
Entry & hallway		☐	☐
Living room		☐	☐
Kitchen: surfaces & cabinets		☐	☐
Kitchen: appliances		☐	☐
Bathroom		☐	☐
Bedroom 1		☐	☐
Bedroom 2 / office		☐	☐
Closets & storage		☐	☐
Windows, blinds & screens		☐	☐
Balcony, patio or other		☐	☐

Tip: write the photo file names or numbers in the notes so each flaw points to its picture.

TENANT _____ LANDLORD / MANAGER _____

SECTION 03
WHAT HOLDS WHAT

No-drill hanging cheat sheet

Match the job to the method. Load levels here are rough categories, not ratings: always check the package rating, and the wall types it lists.

●○○ **LIGHT** keys, a dish towel, a print ●●○ **MEDIUM** a framed print, a coat ●●● **HEAVY** big mirrors, shelves, a TV

METHOD	BEST FOR	LOAD	SURFACE	CLEAN-REMOVAL TIP
Adhesive hooks	Keys, towels, utensils, a bag strap	●○○	Smooth painted walls, tile, glass, metal	For release tabs, stretch down slowly, not out; follow label
Adhesive picture strips (interlocking)	Light framed art and signs; not precious items	●●○	Smooth, clean, cured paint	Follow removal steps; never pull frame or strip out from wall
Adhesive putty	Posters, cards, paper	●○○	Paint, glass	Can leave oily marks on some paint; test a hidden spot
Tension rods	Light curtains, shower curtains, light storage	●●○	Two solid, parallel surfaces	Snug, not forced; rubber caps protect the paint
Tension poles (floor to ceiling)	Corner shelves, plant hangers, room dividers	●●○	Level floor, flat sound ceiling	Use protective pads; recheck tension as instructions direct
Over-the-door hooks & racks	Coats, towels, bags, shoe pockets	●●○	Doors with a gap at the top	Felt pads stop rubbing; check the door still latches
Magnetic hooks & racks	Spices, towels, tools, a light shelf	●○○	Steel doors, fridge sides, metal frames	Test with a fridge magnet first; use a soft backing
Suction cups	Light shower accessories, a razor	●○○	Glass, glossy tile, mirror only	Inspect often; follow the maker's cleaning and release steps
Lean or stand it	Large art, mirrors, bookcases, a TV on a stand	●●●	Floor, dresser, console, freestanding shelf	Use stable supports; secure tip-prone items with approval

Make adhesives actually stick

Clean as the label directs; use alcohol only if allowed for that surface. Press and wait for the listed time. Weigh the complete loaded item and stay within the stated rating; don't invent a rating by adding hooks. Skip fresh paint, texture, wallpaper and damp areas unless explicitly allowed.

Picture ledges & heavy things

A ledge creates leverage. Use only a complete adhesive-rated system within its listed load, never a regular shelf on strips. Heavy mirrors and TVs need a stable stand or approved anchors. Never put adhesive-hung items over a bed or crib.

SECTION 04
GO UP, GO UNDER, GO BEHIND THE DOOR

Storage by room

Small places run out of floor first. Use the height of the room, the space under things and the backs of doors before you buy another bin.

Entry

- Over-the-door hooks for coats and bags
- A slim shoe cabinet, or a bench with a shelf underneath
- One tray for keys, mail and sunglasses, so they don't spread
- An adhesive hook by the door for tomorrow's bag

Kitchen

- Shelf risers double the space in tall cabinets
- A rated tension rod can hold a few spray bottles by their triggers
- Over-cabinet-door racks for lids and wraps (check the door still closes)
- A rolling cart that slides in beside the fridge

Bathroom

- A freestanding shelf over the toilet
- A tension-pole shower caddy instead of a sagging hanging one
- Hooks on the back of the door for towels and robes
- Small bins to tame the under-sink clutter

Bedroom

- Bed-compatible, weight-rated risers plus low bins underneath
- A headboard or nightstand with shelves
- An over-door shoe organizer for scarves, belts and chargers
- Vacuum bags for off-season clothes and spare bedding

Living room

- A storage ottoman or bench that also seats guests
- Tall, narrow shelving that uses the height of the wall
- Baskets on open shelves to hide the mess
- Furniture on legs, so you can see floor underneath

Closet

- A hanging rod extender to double-hang shirts
- Slim, matching hangers take noticeably less room
- Hanging fabric shelves for folded things
- Shelf dividers stop tall stacks from toppling

Tall furniture can tip

Bookcases and dressers can tip over, especially with kids or pets climbing them. Ask your landlord about anti-tip straps; most would rather patch one small hole than deal with an injury. And try one-in, one-out: when something new comes home, something old leaves.

SECTION 05
SEAL, ADD MASS, SOFTEN

Thin walls & noise

Sound gets in through gaps and through thin surfaces. Seal the gaps first, add mass where you can, and soften hard rooms that echo.

Find the leak first

Listen near doors, windows and the shared wall to find the loudest spot. A visible light gap under a door is a useful clue, but sound also travels through walls and floors. Don't block required ventilation.

Keep noise out

- **A door sweep** on the bottom of the door (slide-on or adhesive) plus **foam weatherstrip** around the frame.
- **Heavy curtains** help with echo and may soften some outside sound. They won't block traffic bass.
- **Move storage to the shared wall.** A filled bookcase may soften the impression of sound, but it is not a soundproof wall. Secure it against tipping.
- **Rugs with thick pads** on hard floors cut the echo in your room.
- **Soft furnishings**: upholstered pieces, throws, fabric headboards and cushions all soak up echo.
- **Steady sound** masks voices: a fan, an air purifier or a white-noise machine. Earplugs for sleep.
- **Move the bed** off the shared wall if the layout allows it.

An honest limit: foam panels mostly reduce echo inside your room. They won't stop a neighbor's TV. Mass and sealed gaps do more.

Noise log

DATE / TIME	WHAT YOU HEARD	REPORTED
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

Keep your noise in

- Felt pads on chair and table legs.
- A rug and pad where you walk most, if anyone lives below you.
- Manufacturer-approved anti-vibration pads under noisy appliances; don't move building equipment without permission.
- Speakers on stands, away from shared walls; headphones after quiet hours.
- Soft-close bumpers on cabinet doors that slam.

Talking to a neighbor

"Hi, I'm in 3B. I think our bedrooms share a wall. I'm up at six for work, so would you mind keeping music down after ten? And tell me if I'm ever loud too."

Friendly, specific, and it opens the door both ways. If it keeps happening, check your lease for quiet-hours rules and raise it with management in writing, with dates and times.

Keep a noise log

If you need to escalate, a short list of dates, times and what you heard is far more useful than "it's always loud." Use the log at left, and record any reports in the contact log on page 14.

SECTION 06
LIGHT, BLACKOUT, COOLING WITHOUT AC

Dark or hot room fixes

Rentals tend to come with one overhead light and whatever windows the building gave you. Here's how to work with both.

Brighten a dark room

- **Layer three lights** at different heights: a floor lamp, a table lamp and something low.
- **Plug-in wall sconces** give wall light without wiring; hide cords in an adhesive cord cover.
- **Swap bulbs**: warm (around 2700K) for living rooms, cooler and brighter for kitchens and desks. Keep the originals.
- **Puck or bar lights** under cabinets and in closets. Keep bulbs within each fixture's rating.
- **Use a stable mirror** beside a window to bounce daylight; secure it against tipping with permission.
- **Light textiles**: a pale rug, curtains and bedding lift a dim room when you can't repaint.

Block light for sleep

- **Blackout curtains** on a tension rod inside the window frame, or a wide rod outside it.
- **Light leaking at the sides?** Use wider panels or a wrap-around rod so the fabric meets the wall.
- **A blackout liner** clipped behind the curtains you already have.
- **Static-cling blackout film** only if approved for that glass; some films can overheat sealed glazing.
- **A gap at the top?** A short valance or a strip of fabric over the rod closes it.
- **A sleep mask** is the cheapest backup for shift workers.

Cool down without AC

- **Block the sun early.** Close blinds and curtains on sunny windows before the room heats up.
- **Flush heat at night** only when outside is cooler and the air is safe. Put a fan facing *out*, with another window open. Keep windows child- and pet-safe.
- **Cut indoor heat:** skip the oven on hot days, switch to LED bulbs, unplug things that sit warm.
- **Cool the bed**: breathable cotton or linen sheets, and a fan aimed at you, not the room.
- **Window AC or a portable unit?** Ask your landlord first; many leases cover window units.

Window sun map

Spend one day noticing when sun hits each window. It tells you when to close up and when to open.

ROOM / WINDOW	FACES	DIRECT SUN (TIMES)	PLAN: BLOCK, OPEN, ADD LIGHT

Heat is a safety issue

If your place gets dangerously hot, don't tough it out. Go somewhere cooler for the hottest hours, such as a library, a friend's place or a public cooling center. Check on pets and older neighbors. And if building-supplied cooling is broken, report it in writing.

SECTION 07
REMOVE THE SOURCE, THEN MOVE THE AIR

Pet smells & odor

In a small apartment, smells have nowhere to go. Covering them up never lasts; finding and removing the source does.

Clean it so it's actually gone

- **Trace the source.** Check bedding, litter, rugs and baseboards. A UV light may suggest where to look, but fluorescence alone does not identify urine.
- **Use an enzyme cleaner** for urine and accidents. It breaks down the source; regular cleaners mostly mask it.
- **Blot, don't scrub**, and let the cleaner sit as long as the label says. Test a hidden spot of carpet first.
- **Skip ammonia-based cleaners** on pet accidents; to a pet the smell can read as "go here again."
- **Wash pet bedding** and throws on a schedule, and vacuum fabric furniture.
- **Keep pets away** from wet cleaner until the label says it is safe. Avoid carpet powders that pets could lick or inhale.
- **Move clean air:** ventilate when outdoor air is safe. HEPA captures particles, not odor gases; activated carbon may help with some odors. Skip ozone generators.
- **Go easy on fragrance.** Heavy scents bother many pets, and some essential oils are unsafe for cats and dogs. Ask your vet before using a diffuser.

Not pet-related?

- **Kitchen:** a lidded trash can, emptied often; clean the dishwasher filter and the fridge drip areas.
- **Drains:** remove accessible hair at the strainer. Report repeated blockages or sewer smells; never mix drain cleaners.
- **Musty smells** mean moisture: run fans, dry towels flat, and report any mold to your landlord in writing.

Odor routine

Tick off a week at a time and adjust to your pet.

DAILY

- [ ] Scoop the litter box or clean up the yard spot
- [ ] Take out the kitchen trash if it smells
- [ ] Ventilate if outdoor air and weather allow

WEEKLY

- [ ] Wash pet bedding and couch throws
- [ ] Vacuum floors, rugs and upholstery
- [ ] Wipe the food and water bowl area
- [ ] Wash out the trash can and recycling bin

MONTHLY

- [ ] Wash the litter box as its care guide directs
- [ ] Check purifier and vacuum filters
- [ ] Check rugs for missed accidents

Protect the pet deposit

Photograph floors and baseboards at move-in so older stains are on record, and read your lease's pet clause. Treat accidents the day they happen; old stains are much harder to lift.

SECTION 08
CHANGE IT, THEN CHANGE IT BACK

Upgrades that come off clean

Removable is not the same as damage-free. Choose small, low-risk changes, test first and keep the original parts. If your lease asks for permission, ask before you start.

Contact paper
Shelves, drawer bottoms, dated cabinet fronts and counters. Test a small piece somewhere hidden for a week. Follow its removal guide; use gentle warmth only if allowed and peel slowly at a low angle. Avoid fresh paint and lifting laminate.

Peel-and-stick wallpaper
Best on smooth, cured paint. Hang a test panel in a closet first and leave it a few weeks. To remove, peel it back on itself, not straight out from the wall.

Peel-and-stick backsplash
Covers tired tile or a bare wall behind the sink. Keep it clear of the stove's heat and check that the product is meant for kitchens.

Rugs over bad floors
A large rug with a non-slip pad hides a lot. Check the pad is safe for your floor, since some can mark vinyl or finished wood.

Knobs and pulls
Measure between the screw holes (center to center) so new hardware fits the existing holes. No new holes, and a quick swap back.

Showerhead
Ask first. Follow the fixture instructions for tools, washers and thread tape, check for leaks, and store the original. Stop if the pipe moves.

Lighting
Plug-in sconces, lamps and smart bulbs in existing fixtures. Anything hard-wired: ask your landlord first, and use a licensed electrician if they agree.

Curtains
Hung high and wide on tension or freestanding rods, they make windows look bigger and a room look finished.

Originals log

Bag each original part with its screws, label it, and note where you put it.

WHAT YOU SWAPPED	ROOM / LOCATION	WHERE THE ORIGINAL IS STORED	DATE	PUT BACK
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

SECTION 09
THE DEPOSIT-BACK PLAN

Move-out timeline

Give yourself time to fix, clean and document. This plan helps you prepare a clear record, before the last box leaves.

6–8 weeks out

- [ ] Reread the lease: notice period, cleaning requirements, carpet clauses
- [ ] Give written notice the way the lease requires, and keep a copy
- [ ] Ask for any move-out checklist, and whether they offer a pre-move-out walk-through
- [ ] Dig out your move-in photos and condition log

3–4 weeks out

- [ ] Take down adhesive hooks and strips slowly, using the release tabs
- [ ] Ask before patching or touching up paint; some landlords prefer to do it themselves
- [ ] Put the originals back, using your originals log
- [ ] Book carpet cleaning or movers if you need them
- [ ] Sell, donate or toss what you won't move

Final week

- [ ] Deep clean room by room (checklist on the next page)
- [ ] Replace burnt-out bulbs and alarm batteries if the lease makes that your job
- [ ] Clear the fridge, freezer and every cabinet
- [ ] Schedule utility shut-off or transfer for the day after you leave

Move-out day

- [ ] Once it's empty, photograph and video every room from the same spots as move-in
- [ ] Photograph the meters with readings visible
- [ ] Return every key, fob and remote, and get a receipt or written confirmation
- [ ] Give your forwarding address in writing for the deposit

After you leave

- [ ] Note your local deadline for the deposit or itemized deductions (check local law)
- [ ] If there are deductions, ask in writing for an itemized list with receipts
- [ ] If you disagree, reply in writing with your before-and-after photos

Keep every message

Notice, move-out date, key return, forwarding address: put each one in writing and log it on page 14. A clear, dated timeline helps if there is a disagreement. Deposit return and deductions still depend on the lease and local law.

CHECKLIST THE CLEAN THAT GETS CHECKED

Deposit-back cleaning checklist

Work top to bottom in each room: ceiling, walls, surfaces, then floor. Test any strong cleaner or melamine sponge on a hidden spot first, since some take paint off along with the scuff.

Kitchen

- [ ] Inside the oven, racks and broiler drawer
- [ ] Stovetop, burner pans or grates, and knobs
- [ ] Range hood and its filter
- [ ] Inside the fridge and freezer, plus the seals
- [ ] Behind and under the fridge and stove, if they pull out
- [ ] Microwave inside and out
- [ ] Cabinets and drawers, inside and out
- [ ] Sink, faucet and disposal
- [ ] Dishwasher filter, door edge and seals

Bathroom

- [ ] Tub or shower, tile and grout
- [ ] Glass door, or the curtain rod and hooks
- [ ] Toilet, including the base and behind it
- [ ] Sink, faucet, mirror and medicine cabinet
- [ ] Exhaust fan cover
- [ ] Inside drawers and under the sink

Every room

- [ ] All adhesive residue and putty marks
- [ ] Scuffs and fingerprints on walls
- [ ] Light switches, outlets and door handles
- [ ] Baseboards and door frames
- [ ] Window sills, tracks and blinds
- [ ] Ceiling fans, light covers and vents
- [ ] Closet shelves, rods and floors
- [ ] Every drawer and shelf, emptied and wiped
- [ ] Vacuum, then mop hard floors, edges included

Last walk-through

- [ ] Every light works
- [ ] Nothing left behind, inside or out
- [ ] Trash and recycling out, per building rules
- [ ] Windows locked, faucets off, thermostat set as the lease asks
- [ ] Final photos and video done

Move-out record

Fill this in on the last day. Keep a photo of it with your move-out pictures.

KEYS RETURNED TO _____ DATE & TIME _____

KEYS / FOBS RETURNED _____ FORWARDING ADDRESS _____

ELECTRIC METER _____ GAS METER _____ WATER METER _____

- [ ] Written key-return confirmation received
- [ ] Forwarding address sent in writing
- [ ] Move-out photos and video backed up

DEPOSIT DEADLINE (CHECK LOCAL LAW) _____

WORKSHEET REPAIRS, NOTICES, KEYS, DEPOSIT, NOISE

Landlord-contact log

LANDLORD / MANAGER _____ PHONE _____

EMAIL / PORTAL _____ AFTER-HOURS LINE _____

DATE	HOW	WHAT IT WAS ABOUT	THEIR RESPONSE / NEXT STEP	RESOLVED
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐
				☐

Tip: after a phone call, send a short email ("Thanks for talking today, just confirming...") so it's on record too.

No Holes Needed

Something else bugging you *about your place?*

No Holes Needed has step-by-step guides for the problems a lease won't let you remodel away. Here are a few good places to start.

- Hang art, mirrors & shelves without losing your deposit →
- What adhesive strips really hold on rental paint →
- Small apartment storage when you have no closet →
- How to quiet thin apartment walls →
- How to cool a rental with bad or no AC →
- Pet urine on rental carpet, before it costs you →
- A deposit-safe rental bathroom makeover →

MORE GUIDES AT

noholesneeded.github.io

https://noholesneeded.github.io/

This guide is general information, not legal advice. Check your lease and local landlord-tenant rules, and always check the package rating before hanging or installing anything. Share it with a friend who rents. © 2026 No Holes Needed.